Unit 1 – Types and Sources of Data and an Introduction to R

Unit 1 provided a useful introduction to descriptive statistics and an opportunity to refresh my knowledge of R. Having previously used R during my earlier studies, it took me some time to become familiar with the scripting language again. The lecturecasts were particularly helpful in reminding me how to import datasets into RStudio, navigate the interface and execute basic commands.

One challenge I encountered during the formative assessment involved the COVID-19 dataset, where the dates had been imported as character (text) variables rather than date variables. I initially overlooked this and only realised there was an issue when attempting to calculate the date range, which returned missing values (NA). After reviewing the dataset structure, I identified the problem and used the `as.Date()` function to convert the character values into the appropriate date format. This allowed me to calculate the date range correctly and complete the analysis.

Although a relatively minor issue, it was a useful reminder of the importance of checking the structure of a dataset before carrying out statistical analysis. In general, the unit helped rebuild my confidence in using R and reinforced some of the fundamental concepts involved in working with and interpreting data.